

ACCESS, CONTROL AND USE OF RESOURCES IN AFRICAN AGRICULTURE: AN INTRODUCTION

Sara Berry

Recent literature on the agrarian crisis in Africa questions the adequacy of a technocratic approach to explaining and alleviating the crisis.¹ Bringing about sustained growth in African agricultural output and rural incomes will require more than a technological breakthrough. Farmers' capacity to employ improved technology and to increase output and investment depends on their access to productive resources—broadly defined to include not only human, financial and material inputs, but also the knowledge and institutional means to use them effectively. To advance knowledge of the causes of the agrarian crisis and strengthen capacity to develop meaningful measures to alleviate it, it is necessary to understand the conditions under which African farmers gain access to productive resources and the ways in which conditions of access affect resource use and agricultural performance.

In the following collection the articles by Okoth-Ogendo, Blaikie and Berry and the comment by Okali outline alternative conceptual approaches to documenting and analysing resource access and resource use in sub-Saharan Africa. These articles were originally presented at the annual meeting of the (US) African Studies Association in 1986. The panel was organised by the Joint African Studies Committee of the ACLS and SSRC as part of a long-term project to establish a framework for interdisciplinary analysis of the crisis in African agriculture. Scholars from several disciplines were asked to prepare articles which posed questions and outlined possible analytical approaches for further research, rather than to present specific research findings. The articles are accordingly exploratory in tone and eclectic in conceptual approach. C. Okali served as discussant on the panel; her article is based on her comments.

In contrast, the papers by Haugerud and Mackenzie are case studies. Both present results of original field research on recent trends in land access and use in neighbouring rural districts of Kenya. The essays have been included in this collection to draw attention to the growing corpus of recent or current empirical research on resource access and use in African agrarian systems, and to illustrate potential applications of some of the approaches proposed in the general papers. Neither the general articles nor the case studies are intended to be representative of on-going research or exhaustive in their treatment of the general subject of resource access and resource use.

For the most part the authors of the general articles interpret their terms of reference broadly. Access implies the right to use or benefit from a productive resource; control refers to the effective exercise of such rights. The difference is significant in situations where rights of access are not acted upon—as, for example, when land is left uncultivated by those who hold rights to farm it. Access may also diverge from control when rights are in dispute and claimants are prevented from exercising them by actual or threatened opposition from rival claimants or by the action of administrative or judicial authorities. A central theme in these articles is that conditions of

access and control over agricultural resources in Africa have undergone (or are undergoing) change, leading to uncertainty and/or tension, which may in turn affect strategies of resource use.

In principle, productive resources may also be broadly defined to include not only material and financial means of production—land, labour, fixed and working capital—but also social relations and knowledge which may be employed in processes of production. However, most of the papers in the collection actually focus on one particular resource—land or landed property. Land is obviously necessary to agricultural production, but it is by no means the only resource to be considered. Indeed, it has been argued that in many African economies land is not the principal constraint on agricultural output, and that rural development programmes which take increasing yields as their principal objective are inappropriate for Africa. It may therefore be wondered whether the focus on land in these essays limits or biases their usefulness.

Actually, the focus on land is not as restrictive as it sounds. Taken together the papers show that access to land, labour and capital is often interrelated in African rural economies; hence analysis of rights in land promotes rather than precludes consideration of access to resources in general. Okoth-Ogendo argues, for example, that systems of land tenure are not just sets of rules concerning rights in land but also involve the allocation of power within a society and its exercise with respect to land use. In Africa power over land is 'an incident of membership in some unit of production' (Okoth-Ogendo, p. 10) or other social group (Berry, pp. 41–2). Hence land may be viewed not only as a direct input to agricultural production but also as a focus for the definition and exercise of rights of access which extend to other productive resources as well. 'Land is an important social asset in Africa . . . ; [it is] one means by which [people] maintain local and descent group affiliations . . . ' (Haugerud, p. 62). In turn, social affiliations and socially constructed identities (such as gender or generation) often convey or mediate access to labour, capital, knowledge and authority as well as land. Indeed, in so far as resource access hinges on social identity or group membership, identity and membership are themselves resources, which bear directly on production and may become objects of accumulation (Berry, pp. 43, 46).

Several of the articles explore implications of the idea that 'access to and control of power over land are multiplex phenomena that will vary in nature and content with the kind of land use activity in which an individual member of society is or a group of such members are involved' (Okoth-Ogendo, p. 11). Okoth-Ogendo suggests that persons in positions of authority are obligated to protect the interests of their subordinates and 'the outright disposal of land to persons external to a given unit of production is therefore alien to African land law' (*idem*). Hence there has been no general tendency in Africa for agricultural commercialisation and technical change to consolidate land rights in the hands of a few at the expense of many, or to replace multiple, varied rights with exclusive forms of control. In Embu, Haugerud found that land tenure has been related to agricultural production in complex ways. For example, registration of individual titles in Kenya has fostered land mortgaging and sale but, contrary to planners' expectations, this has not led to agricultural investment.

Understanding access as a social process also affects the way one thinks about strategies of land use. If access to productive resources is associated with membership in social groups, then the structure of relations among group members will influence patterns of production and resource use. Since, as Okoth-Ogendo points out, it is likely that different members of a descent group or community exercise different degrees of power, patterns of production will change as a result of the dynamics of social interaction within the group as a whole—not just in response to changes in the rules of land tenure. Berry explores the implications of group structure for the management of production. She suggests that, in so far as resource-controlling groups follow inclusive strategies of recruitment and control, they do not necessarily function to maximise labour productivity.

How do patterns of resource access and use vary across different environments in Africa? This is an important question not systematically addressed in these articles. Blaikie does, however, call attention to the problem of environmental degradation in Africa and suggests that access may play an important role both in causing environmental degradation and in shaping people's responses to it. Challenging the terms of previous debate over the causes of environmental degradation in Africa, Blaikie argues that the question is not whether soil degradation in Africa is a 'natural' or a man-made phenomenon, but how environmental factors have interacted with the social organisation of land use to influence soil quality over time. He proposes to analyse such interactions with a recursive decision-making model in which the 'access profile of the decision-making unit' helps to determine a 'feasible subset' of strategies for coping with soil degradation (Blaikie, p. 33).

The usefulness of Blaikie's model for explaining patterns of land use and their consequences clearly depends on the kind and quality of evidence to which it is applied. The decision-making process he is modelling comes into play only if producers 'diagnose' land degradation as a problem, although, as Blaikie points out, producers' diagnosis at one point in time may be influenced by the land-use practices of their predecessors. In recent years scholars have become increasingly aware of the merits of indigenous African technical knowledge and of the fact that policy makers and farmers may bring different bodies of technical knowledge to bear on formulating strategies of soil management and land use. Clearly they may also diagnose problems and specify objectives in different ways. Faced in the 1950s with 'land degradation and coercive conservation policies imposed by colonial authorities', Kikuyu farmers diagnosed their problem 'as one of the alienation of land by settlers leading to instant "over-population"', and found the 'political solution of ridding themselves of the British [more appealing] than costly conservation works' (Blaikie, p. 32).

Does it follow that to analyse the dynamics of resource access and use one must choose between local and external diagnoses? Does the effort to understand and build on African systems of technical knowledge and social analysis preclude the use of non-African conceptual frameworks? Some would argue that conceptual obstacles to cross-cultural communication concerning agrarian change and agricultural technology are part of the agrarian crisis.² Alternatively, by seeking to understand the way in which Western scientific and indigenous African systems of knowledge have

interacted to shape patterns of agricultural production and change in the past, it may be possible to work towards a more effective integration of

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SOME ISSUES OF THEORY IN THE STUDY OF TENURE RELATIONS IN AFRICAN AGRICULTURE

H. W. O. Okoth-Ogendo

PROLEGOMENON

What has become known as 'the African agrarian crisis' is an extremely complex phenomenon. This much is clear from the fact that, despite the very considerable amount of literature which has been accumulated on the subject (Berry, 1984), there is still very little agreement as to its precise nature and dimensions and even less certainty on how to resolve it in the context of national level policies, plans and programmes. What this must mean, *inter alia*, is that explanations cannot be sought simply in pithy epigrams drawn from grand theories and hastily assembled micro-level data bases.

Perhaps for that reason there is renewed interest and faith in interdisciplinary co-operation in the study of African agrarian systems even though nobody believes for one moment that that will yield the 'correct' view of the crisis or of the best and most effective way of resolving it. The only *a priori* claim that can be made for such co-operation is that it casts the widest net and hence is likely to have the greater heuristic value even if, for precisely that reason, analysis of data may be more cumbersome.

These articles are a first step in the development of an interdisciplinary framework for the analysis of one particular facet of African agrarian systems, namely the structures and processes through which agricultural communities gain access to, exercise control over and exploit particular resource elements which enter into agricultural production, and how these change in the course of interaction with other social, economic, political and scientific processes over time. Specifically the articles seek to clarify those matters of theory and policy which require further elaboration and to identify programmes of research which still need to be pursued in order fully to understand the centrality of resource control in the dynamics of African agriculture.

This article seeks to contribute to that exercise by focusing on land *tenure* issues, particularly those concerning nature and judicial content, the role of tenure as a mechanism for determining access to and control over agricultural land, how tenure regimes respond to changes in the technology of production and how those responses affect production processes in agriculture as a whole. These are issues in respect of which a vast amount of literature already exists (Land Tenure Centre, 1976; Berry, 1984). This article therefore confines itself to those aspects of theory which are critical to the appreciation of that literature and which help define the point of departure for further research in this area.

THE DIMENSIONS OF TENURE

The fact that the literature is replete with varying descriptions of what tenure regimes in Africa are thought to be has been noted by many students of African agrarian systems (Elias, 1956; Bohannon, 1963; Gluckman, 1965; Okoth-Ogendo, 1986). What is not so abundant is a body of theory by which

and experiment in an African rice-farming system, (London. Allen & Unwin, 1986); Jane Guyer (ed), *Feeding African Cities*, (Bloomington, Indiana. Indiana University Press for the International African Institute, 1987)

² I am grateful to Paul Richards for raising this point, and I am responsible for the treatment of it herein.

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